

EUROPEAN ECONOMICS ANALYST

UK—The Economic Cost of Brexit, Ten Years On

- The UK economy has materially underperformed since the 2016 EU referendum, shifting from a growth profile closer to the US to one closer to the Euro area. Our updated “Doppelgänger” analysis suggests real GDP is around 6% below its counterfactual path, more than our previous 5% estimate two years ago. While these figures could capture the impact of other factors as well as Brexit, robustness checks point to an underperformance of at least 4%. These estimates are broadly consistent with other studies. Model-based estimates of the cost of leaving the EU average around 5%, while recent empirical research finds a 6–8% impact.
- Analysis of the channels through which Brexit could have affected output also points to a significant drag. Goods trade volumes have underperformed by 10–15% since the referendum. Services trade has held up better, but recent studies nonetheless find a meaningful Brexit-related hit. Lower trade intensity has likely reduced productivity, lowering GDP by 2–4%. Business investment has also been weak since 2016—with business surveys suggesting this is partly due to Brexit—likely lowering output by 2%. The impact on labour supply through migration has been more mixed, with lower EU immigration but higher non-EU inflows. That said, shifting migration patterns have probably contributed to labour shortages in some sectors.
- Taken together, our estimates indicate that Brexit has materially weighed on Britain’s economic performance relative to other advanced economies. While new trade agreements could, in principle, help mitigate some of the costs of Brexit, the benefit from new (non-EU) trade deals is likely to be small.
- That said, we see two reasons why the peak Brexit headwind might now be behind us. First, estimates point to a front-loaded drag, suggesting that the Brexit growth headwind should ease over time. Second, opinion polls now show greater support for a closer EU relationship, and the government is pursuing more EU-UK cooperation. An ambitious reset—such as closer single-market or customs-union alignment—could reverse a meaningful share of the Brexit cost and support stronger trend growth. Consistent with this, we expect average growth in the UK to pick up from 1.2% since 2016 to 1.5% over the coming years.

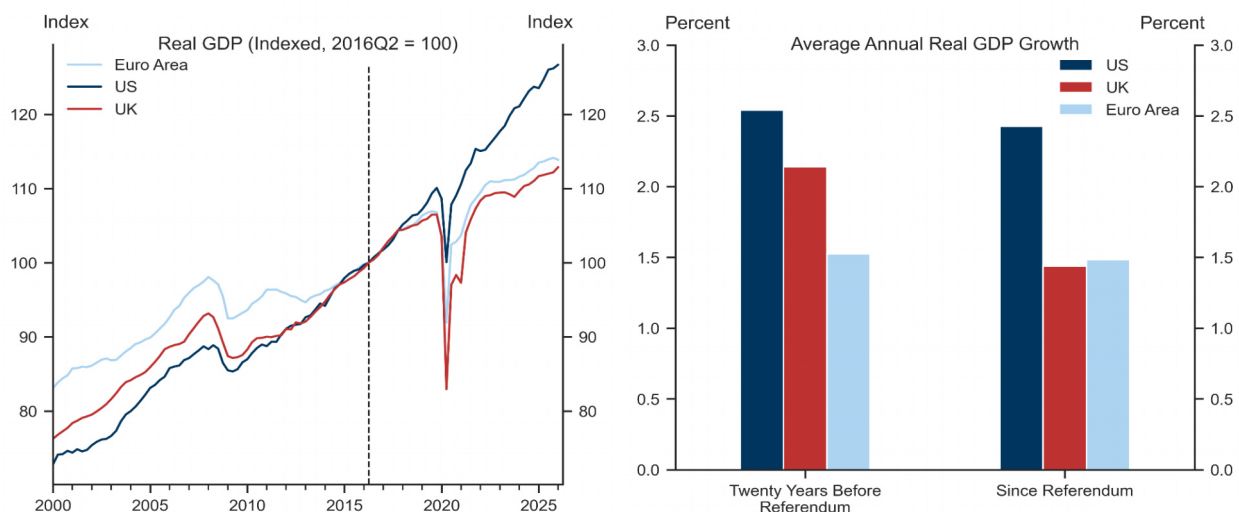
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The UK voted to leave the EU ten years ago this week and has underperformed other advanced economies significantly since then (Exhibit 1). UK growth looked more similar to the US in the twenty years leading up to the referendum, but more similar to the Euro area in the subsequent ten years.

Exhibit 1: UK Growth Was Closer to the US Before Brexit, More Like the Euro Area Since Then



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

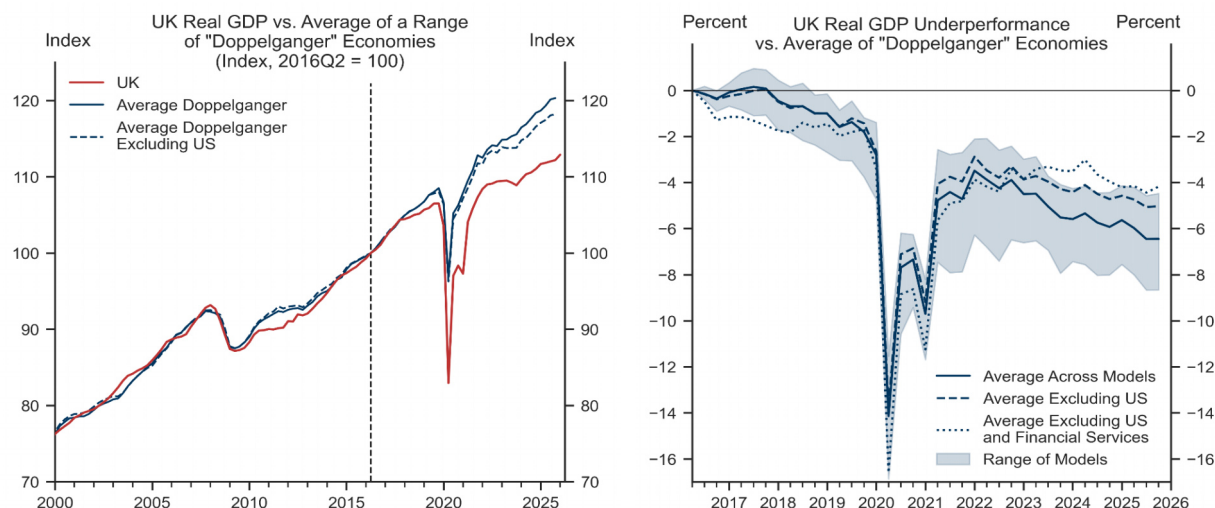
Given the ten-year anniversary of the referendum, we take stock of the macroeconomic costs of the Brexit vote and update our 2024 estimates.

Counting the Cost

We start by examining empirically how much UK real GDP has underperformed other advanced economies since 2016 using a “Doppelgänger” analysis.¹ This method uses statistical techniques to find the best combination of other countries that match the path of UK real GDP before the referendum and uses this same combination to project what might have happened thereafter.

Our estimates suggest that the UK has fallen short of its Doppelgänger by 6% since the referendum, compared with the 5% we estimated two years ago (Exhibit 2, left). Varying the group of countries in the analysis—including the G7, G10, OECD, OECD Europe—points to a range of 4–8% for the output cost (Exhibit 2, right).

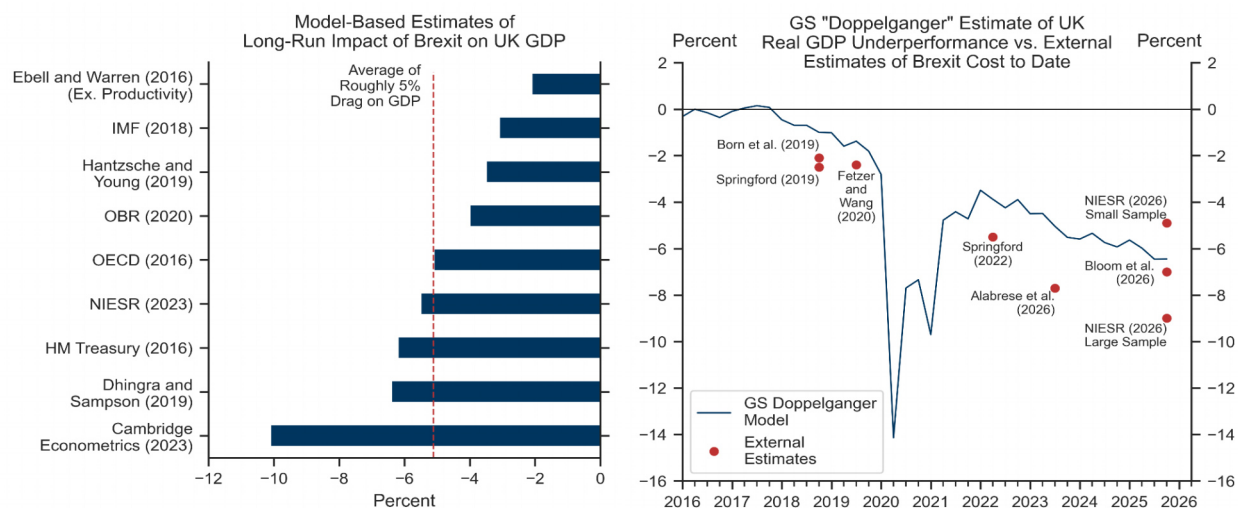
¹ This synthetic control method was applied to Brexit by Benjamin Born and co-authors in “The Costs of Economic Nationalism: Evidence from the Brexit Experiment,” May 2019.

Exhibit 2: Our Doppelgänger Model Points to Significant Underperformance Since the Referendum

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

A shortcoming of the Doppelgänger approach is that not all of the post-2016 underperformance can be attributed to Brexit, as other structural changes have affected Britain's relative economic performance. In particular, the inclusion of the US could skew the estimates, as the US has benefited from a much larger technology boom than other advanced economies during this time. Excluding the US from the Doppelgänger analysis points to a smaller output cost at 5% (dashed line in Exhibit 2, right). It is also possible that UK growth was temporarily boosted by a booming financial sector before the referendum relative to other advanced economies. Re-running the analysis on UK GDP without the financial sector and again excluding the US points to 4% underperformance, which is likely to be a lower-bound estimate (dotted line in Exhibit 2, right).

Our Doppelgänger estimates are consistent with prior studies for the economic cost of Brexit. Model-based studies—which simulate the economic repercussions of greater trade frictions outside of the EU—point to a total output cost of Brexit of around 5% (Exhibit 3, left). The latest empirical studies—often using Doppelgänger models—point to a hit of 6-8%, which has grown notably in recent years (Exhibit 3, right). We provide a more detailed summary of these studies in the appendix.

Exhibit 3: Studies Point to a Large (and Rising) Cost of Brexit

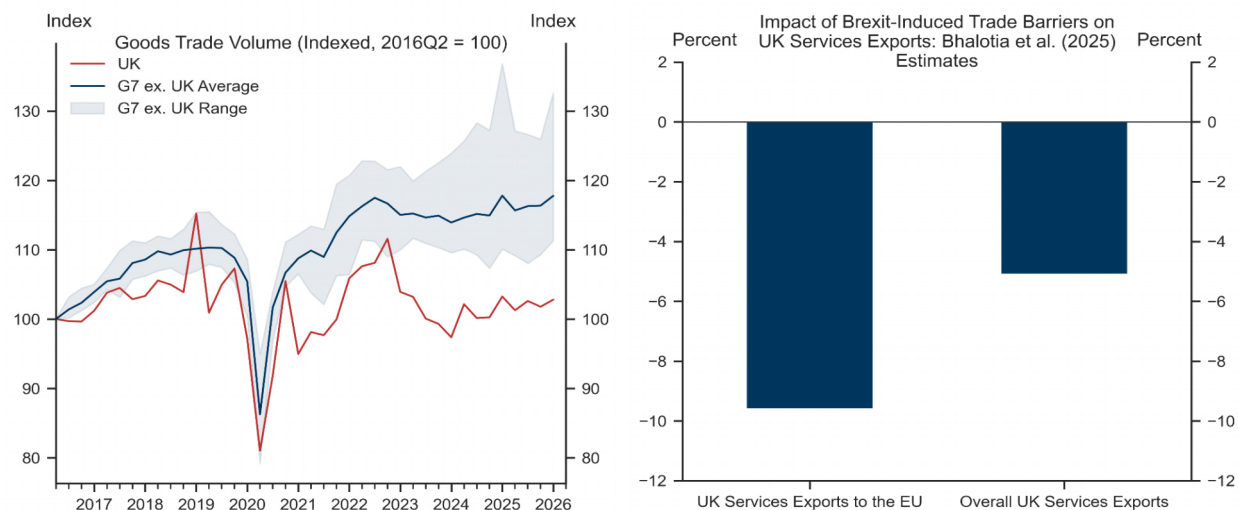
Ebell and Warren (2016) note that incorporating productivity losses would substantially increase their estimates.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Various academic studies

Assessing the Channels

Given uncertainty around the top-down estimates, we consider the mechanisms of Brexit to help gauge how much of the UK's underperformance can be attributed to Brexit. Studies generally consider three mechanisms through which Brexit could have lowered long-term output: (1) international trade, (2) business investment and (3) immigration.

First, the UK has materially underperformed other advanced economies in terms of trade since 2016. We estimate that goods trade volumes would be 10-15% higher in a counterfactual in which volumes had grown in line with the average of other G7 economies, reflecting higher trade frictions outside of the EU (Exhibit 4, left). Services trade has held up better. Recent studies, however, also point to a significant hit to services trade as a result of leaving the EU (Exhibit 4, right).

Exhibit 4: UK Trade Has Been Hit

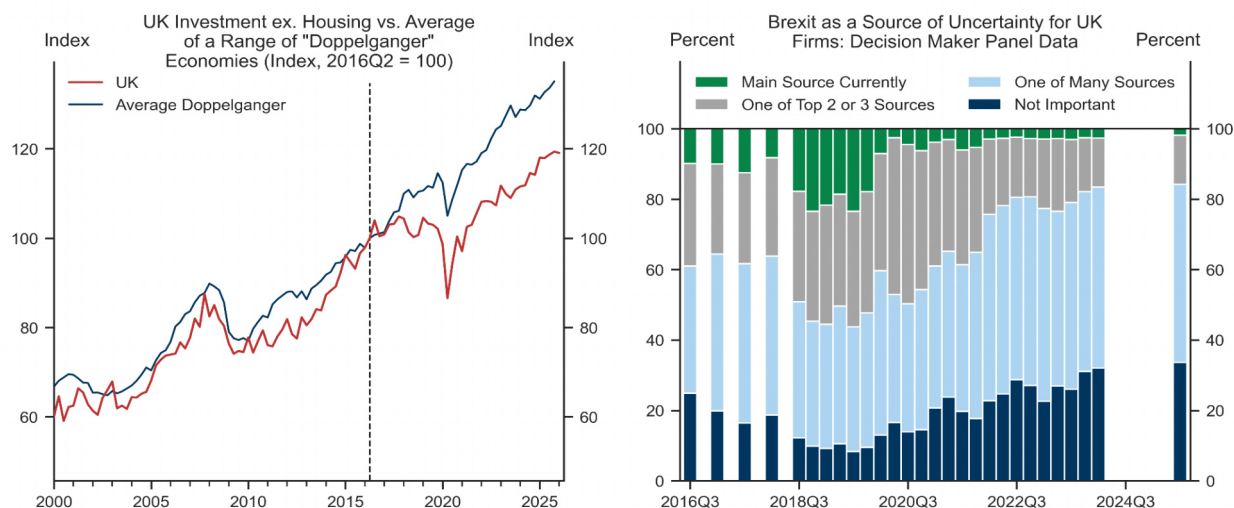
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bhalotia et al. (2025)

Overall, the trade estimates point to a roughly 5-10% decline in trade volumes due to Brexit. Previous studies suggest that a decline in trade intensity of this magnitude could have reduced GDP by 2-4% through reduced productivity.²

Second, UK investment growth stalled after the referendum, falling significantly below its pre-2016 trend (Exhibit 5, left). Our Doppelgänger estimates for investment point to a shortfall of around 10% relative to other economies. At least some of this underperformance likely reflected Brexit uncertainty after the referendum, with surveys clearly flagging Brexit as a source of uncertainty (Exhibit 5, right). Our estimates on the business investment channel imply an output hit of just over 2% by end-2025.³

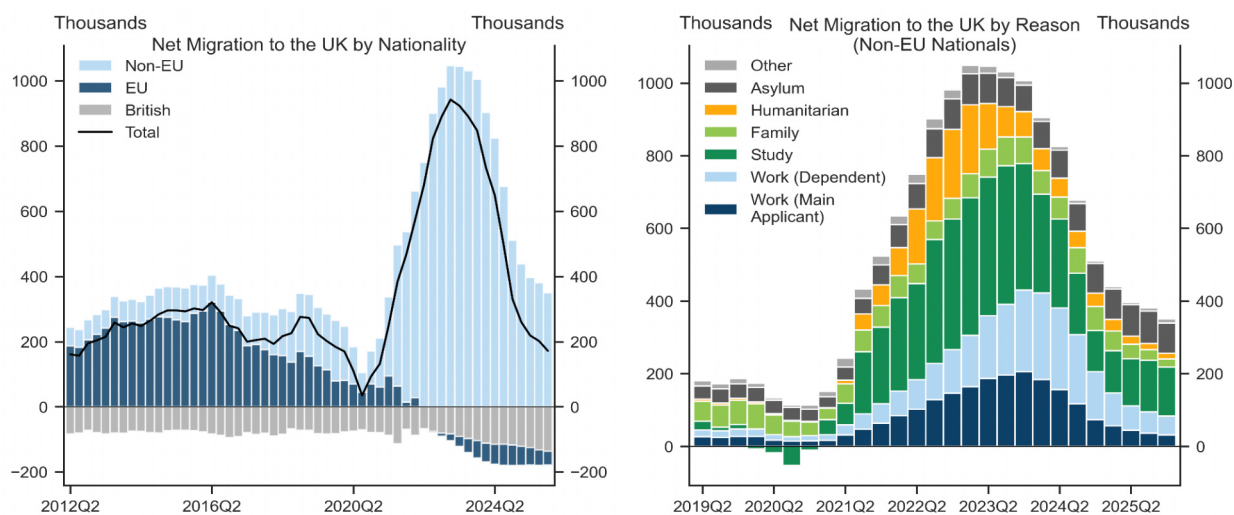
² Two studies by Feyrer using different methodologies have estimated that each 1% reduction in trade lowers GDP by around $\frac{1}{4}\%$ or $\frac{1}{2}\%$.

³ Haskel and Martin (2023) estimated that weakness in business investment after the referendum had lowered output by 1.3% by 2022.

Exhibit 5: Investment Has Underperformed

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bank of England

Third, Brexit has affected immigration flows into the UK. Net migration from the EU has fallen sharply from a peak of over 300k in the year to 2016Q2 to -42k in 2025 (Exhibit 6, left). At the same time, net migration from outside the EU rose significantly to over 1m per year after the pandemic. Although much of the pickup in non-EU immigration reflects reasons other than work (Exhibit 6, right), recent [research](#) suggests that the new immigration system has so far led to a modest net increase in the number of foreign-born people in work. That said, net migration has dropped sharply recently, partly reflecting new government policies.

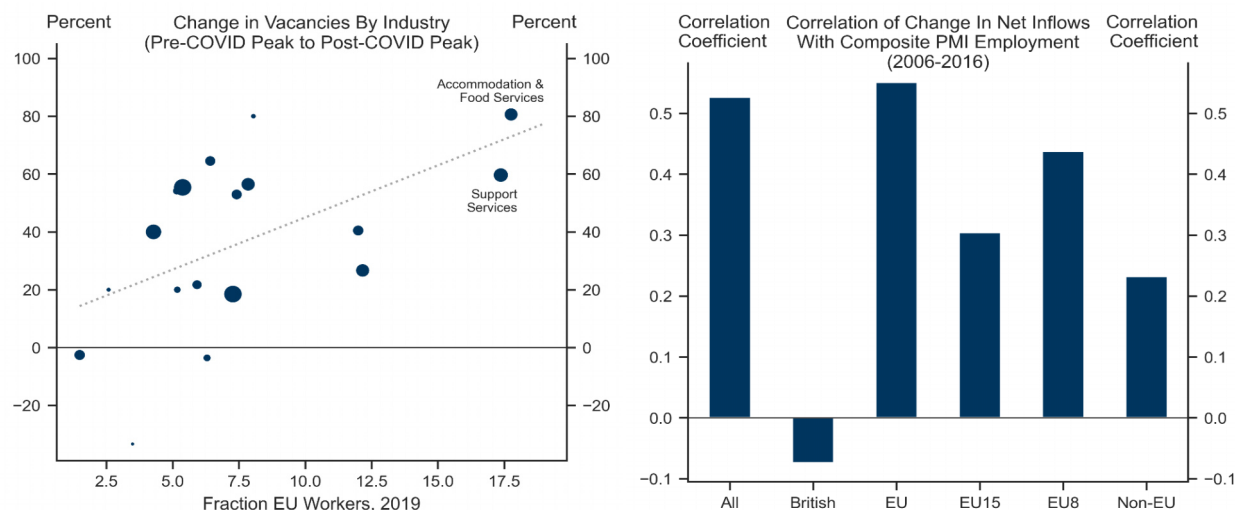
Exhibit 6: Net Migration from the EU Has Fallen but Overall Inflows Rose Post-Pandemic

Source: ONS

Despite the rise in net migration after Brexit, our previous [work](#) suggests that changes in the immigration system have probably contributed to labour shortages. EU nationals have historically been concentrated in lower-skilled occupations and are harder to replace under the new skill-selective migration regime. The sectors that are most reliant on EU workers have experienced the largest increases in vacancy rates since the Covid

pandemic (Exhibit 7, left). Going forward, reduced cyclical volatility of migration flows compared with the pre-Brexit period (Exhibit 7, right) could lead to greater volatility in labour market tightness and domestic inflationary pressures.

Exhibit 7: Lower Immigration from the EU Helps Explain Labour Shortages



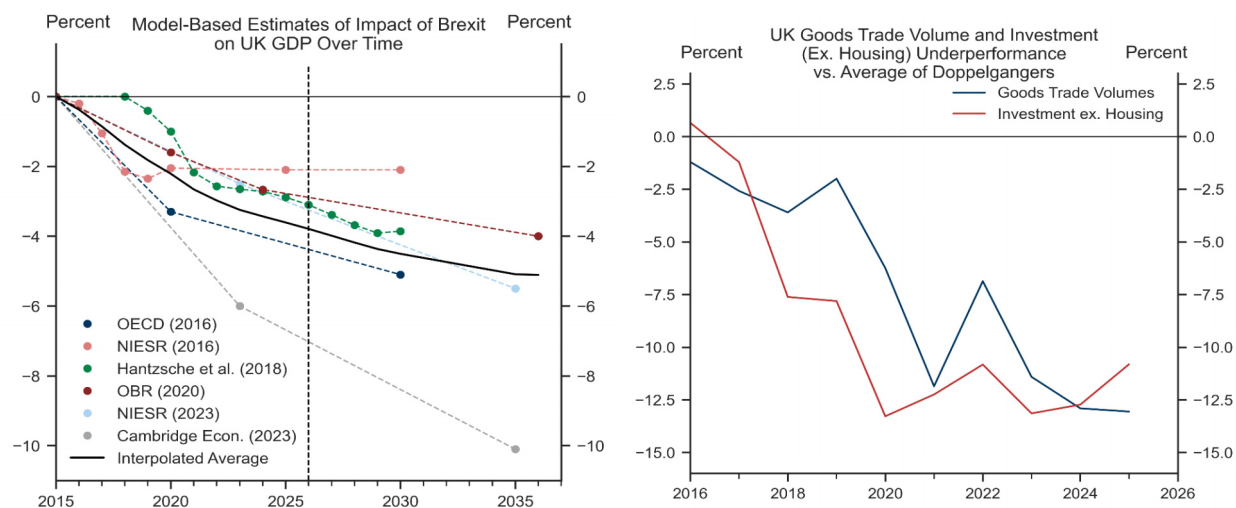
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, ONS

As Bad as It Gets?

Taken together, our estimates show that Brexit has materially weighed on Britain's economic performance relative to other advanced economies. While new trade agreements could, in principle, help mitigate some of the costs of Brexit, the benefit from new (non-EU) trade deals is likely to be small.

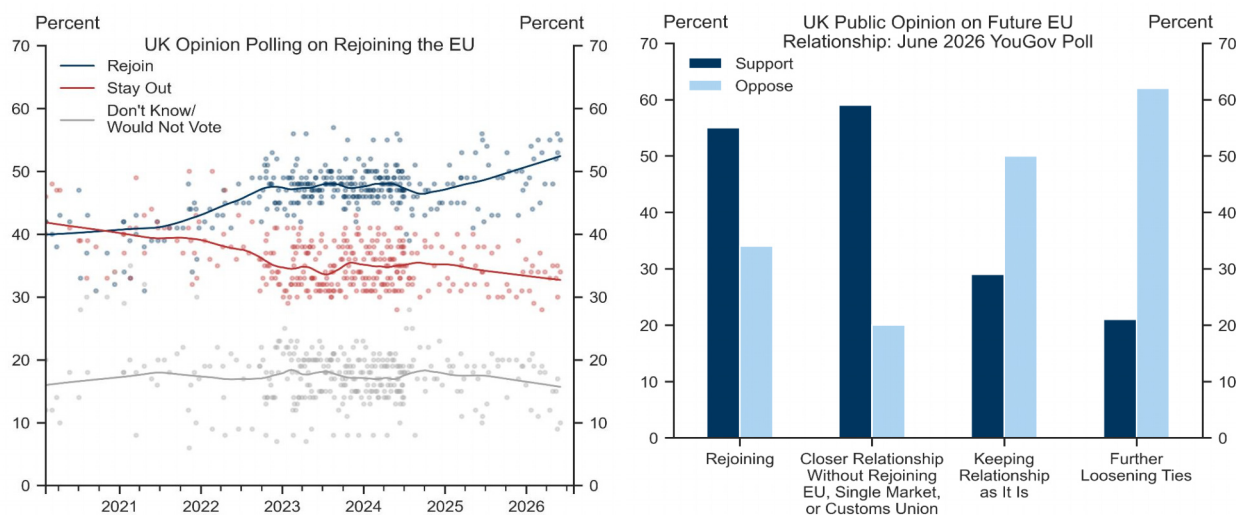
That said, we see two reasons to think that the worst of the Brexit headwind might now be behind us.

First, although the full impact of leaving the EU is likely to take time to materialise, several studies point to a front-loaded growth drag (Exhibit 8, left). Decision Maker Panel data and our own analysis indicate that much of the impact on investment had already come through before the UK left the EU at the end of 2020 as businesses anticipated future disruption to trade barriers. Although there is evidence that trade flows can take 7-10 years to adjust fully to new trade barriers, the shortfall in goods trade volumes relative to other economies shows some signs of levelling off in the last two years (Exhibit 8, right). It is true that the UK's underperformance on GDP has continued to build, perhaps reflecting lags from lower investment and trade into productivity. But these factors suggest that the growth hit is likely to gradually ease over time.

Exhibit 8: Past the Peak Brexit Growth Headwind

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Various academic studies

Second, recent opinion polls and political shifts point to building support for a closer EU-UK relationship. Public opinion polls show that a majority of the UK population now support rejoining the EU (52%), up notably since Covid and now comfortably ahead of the 33% share supporting Brexit (Exhibit 9, left). Public support is highest for a closer relationship with Europe without rejoining the EU, Single Market or Customs Union (Exhibit 9, right). As a result, the government has worked towards a “reset” in EU-UK relations and Andy Burnham (who is likely to succeed Prime Minister Starmer) has historically supported closer integration with Europe.

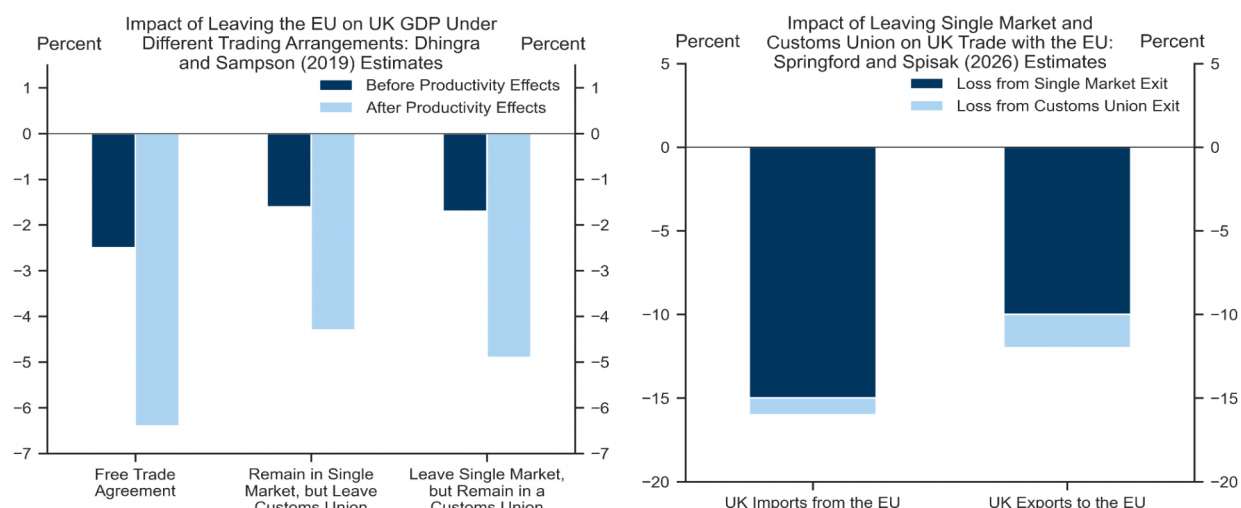
Exhibit 9: Public Opinion Has Shifted in Favour of a Closer Relationship

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Various polling companies, YouGov

The government could start by finalising the veterinary agreement, negotiating mutual recognition of professional qualifications, and aligning with EU rules where it is of clear economic benefit (e.g., for chemicals or the automotive sector). A more ambitious reset further down the line—such as rejoining the single market or negotiating a customs union—could raise GDP by 1-2% and thereby undo a meaningful share of the economic

cost incurred by Brexit (Exhibit 10).

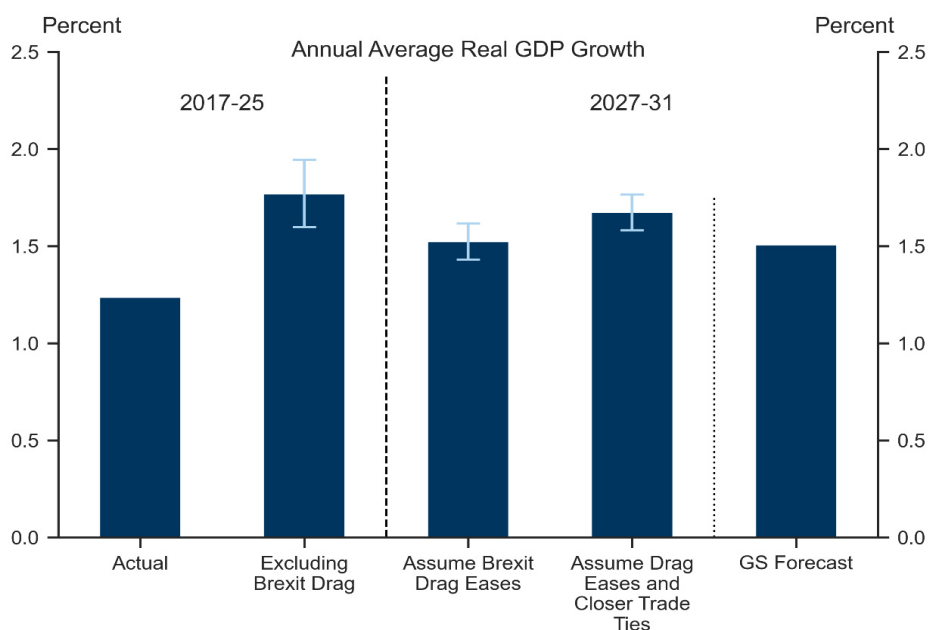
Exhibit 10: A Closer Economic Relationship Could Mitigate Some of the Brexit Costs



Source: Dhingra and Sampson (2019), Springford and Spisak (2026)

The combination of a receding Brexit headwind and a closer economic relationship with the EU could improve the UK's growth performance significantly in coming years (Exhibit 11). Simple calculations suggest that—assuming an unchanged underlying growth pace—UK trend growth could pick up to 1.5% in coming years with a diminishing Brexit drag. That figure could rise to 1.7% in the event of a significant reset of EU-UK relations.

Exhibit 11: An Easing Brexit Drag Could See Trend Growth Improve



“Excluding Brexit drag” uses the average of the GS doppelganger estimate and the growth headwind implied by the model-based estimates shown in Exhibit 8 (left). The light blue bracket shows the range from those two approaches. “Assuming Brexit Drag Eases” assumes that the drag fades in line with the time profile from the model-based estimates. “Closer Trade Ties” assumes a boost of 1-2% from a more ambitious reset over 10 years.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

While there is considerable uncertainty around the exact timing and magnitude of that improvement, the likely scale of the drag on growth over the past decade and the potential upside from a closer EU-UK relationship suggests that the upside is material. Consistent with this, we expect average growth in the UK to pick up from 1.2% since 2016 to 1.5% over the coming years.

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Appendix

Exhibit 12: Studies Estimating the Impact of Brexit on UK GDP

Model-Based Estimate of Long-Run Impact of Brexit			Tracking Estimates of the Impact of Brexit on GDP to Date		
HM Treasury	2016	6.2% under a bilateral agreement over 15 years	Born et al.	2019	1.7-2.5% by the end of 2018
OECD	2016	3.3% by 2020, 5.1% by 2030	Springford (CER)	2019	2.5% by the end of 2018
NIESR	2016	2.1% under FTA ex. productivity; productivity effects could increase cost significantly further	Fetzer and Wang	2020	2.3-2.5% aggregate impact by 2019, 8.5% in worst affected regions
Dhingra et al. (LSE/CEP)	2017	1.3-2.7% ex. productivity; 6.3-9.4% inc. productivity	Springford (CER)	2022	5.5% by 2022Q2
IMF	2018	2.6-3.9% under FTA, average of 3.1%	Alabrese et al.	2026	7.7% by 2023
Hantzsche et al. (NIESR)	2018	3.9% under May deal	Bloom et al.	2026	6-8% by end of 2025
Dhingra and Sampson (LSE/CEP)	2019	2.5% ex. productivity, 6.4% inc. productivity under Johnson deal	NIESR	2026	4.9-9.0% by end 2025, depending on comparison group of countries
Hantzsche and Young (NIESR)	2019	3.5% under Johnson deal			
OBR	2020	4% in the long-run under an FTA			
NIESR	2023	2-3% by 2023, 5-6% by 2035			
Cambridge Econometrics	2023	6.0% by 2023, 10.1% by 2035			

Source: Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Various academic studies

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